

December 15, 2023

Utah State Board of Education
PO Box 144200
250 East 500 South
Salt Lake City, UT 84114-4200

Re: Vista Charter School Administration departure from Charter and related consequences

Dear Appropriate Board Representative:

My name is Kalynn Snow. I am currently a 6th and 7th grade math teacher at Vista. I have been teaching there since the school opened in 2009. After accepting my offer of employment there I actually served on the committee charged with selecting the balance of the faculty. For most of those years I have been the math department chairperson and the coach of the mathcounts team. From the beginning, regardless of the math textbook/program chosen by the school, I have been able to develop my own curriculum and adapt to each class as necessary.

Beginning in 2021-2022 school year Vista entered into a 5-year contract with Carnegie Learning/Mathia as the chosen program from which math was to be taught. During the first two school years I used the program but found it necessary to use my own modifications to teach the basic principles covered by the program's lessons. However, beginning with this school year, the school's administration has directed us to follow, with fidelity, the Carnegie approach which includes **"no direct instruction"** from the teacher. This has been disastrous as students really have no guidance in learning the basis concepts and math principles of each lesson. (A more detailed description of the Carnegie/Mathia approach can be discovered on the company's website. Reviews of the program, both positive and negative can also be found.)

Our School Charter and School website states that ***"Because Vista is not part of a traditional school district, teachers are free to pursue instruction methods that yield the best results, instead of a predetermined curriculum and teaching delivery method."*** The website also states that Vista employs ***"Highly qualified teachers in an environment where instruction is supported by administration."***

Prior to this school year, I believe those statements were true and contributed to the successful learning process of our students. This year is different. The administration has departed from standing by these statements in our charter and will not allow teachers to pursue instruction methods that yield the best results. With no direct instruction allowed, the students are floundering.

After receiving pressure from the administration to follow the Carnegie program "with fidelity" I found it necessary to resign. This has broken my heart, mainly on behalf of the students, but also knowing that other faculty members are also struggling to continue to be effective. I feel that the Board of Education along with the Utah State Charter School Board need to be aware of this situation. I have a good relationship with the President of the School's board of directors, and she is already aware of what has been happening.

My purpose and hope of this communication is that something be done for the sake of the students. If departing from the charter triggers any review of Vista by your organization, please proceed as appropriate. I was informed by the administration that my actions are forcing them to amend the charter regarding the statement about teachers being free to pursue effective instruction methods. They have already, in a desperate manner, edited the statements on the school's website to better present the new and current role the administration is taking with regards to curriculum choice and teaching delivery methods.

Thank you for your consideration of this matter.

Respectfully submitted,

Kalynn B. Snow

